

The Final 20 Days Sprint Plan

A day-by-day plan for the last three weeks before the IMAT. What to do, in what order, and what to stop doing.

Twenty days is short. It is not nothing.

You cannot relearn the syllabus in 20 days. You can absolutely stop losing points you are currently losing for reasons that have nothing to do with how much you know.

That gap is bigger than most candidates think. In the mock exams we review, a large share of wrong answers are not knowledge gaps at all. They are misread questions, rushed final steps, and time that ran out before easy questions at the end were ever reached. Those are all fixable inside three weeks. New content is not.

The one rule for the next 20 days

No new topics. Everything from here is repair, simulation and consolidation. If you have not covered something by now, the cost of starting it exceeds what you would gain from tightening what you already have.

Who wrote this

We are Rom and Maya. We are both medical students at the University of Padova, both scored among the highest IMAT results worldwide, and we mentor a small number of candidates each cycle, personally. This plan is the one we would give a student sitting down with us today, 20 days out.

How to use it if you have fewer than 20 days

The plan is numbered by days remaining, not by calendar date, so it works whenever you pick it up. If you are 14 days out, start at Day 14 and accept that the diagnostic phase gets compressed. Do not skip the first mock exam to save time. Everything after it depends on knowing where you actually stand.

What this is not

It is not a course, not a syllabus, and not a promise. Nobody can guarantee you a score or a seat, and anyone who does is selling you something. This is a plan. What it is worth depends entirely on what you do with it.

The exam, in one page

Everything in this plan refers back to these numbers. If you take nothing else from this guide, take the section weights.

SECTION	QUESTIONS	SHARE	POINTS AVAILABLE
Biology	23	38.3%	34.5
Chemistry	15	25.0%	22.5
Physics & Mathematics	13	21.7%	19.5
Logical Reasoning & Problems	5	8.3%	7.5
Reading Skills & Knowledge Acquired in Studies	4	6.7%	6.0
Total	60	100%	90.0

Format

- 60 multiple-choice questions
- 100 minutes total
- 5 options per question, labelled A to E
- Exactly one correct answer

Scoring

- **+1.5** for a correct answer
- **-0.4** for a wrong answer
- **0** for a blank
- Maximum score: **90 points**

1 minute 40 seconds per question

That is the average you get across all 60. You will not have spare time at the end, which is why the skip decision on Day 9 matters as much as any content you revise.

Format and section proportions reflect the current post-2024 CINECA / University structure, consistent across the 2023, 2024 and 2025 papers. Always confirm the current year's official details on [universitaly.it](https://www.universitaly.it).

The scoring maths almost nobody does

The -0.4 penalty makes most candidates afraid to guess. That fear costs more points than the penalty ever does.

Here is the actual expected value of a guess, depending on how many options you can rule out first. This is simple arithmetic, and it changes how you should behave for roughly 10 to 15 questions on the paper.

OPTIONS YOU CAN RULE OUT	OPTIONS LEFT	CHANCE CORRECT	EXPECTED POINTS
None (blind guess)	5	20%	-0.02
One	4	25%	+0.08
Two	3	33%	+0.23
Three	2	50%	+0.55
You know it	1	100%	+1.50

The rule this gives you

Rule out one option and guessing is already worth it. Rule out none and a blind guess costs you almost exactly nothing (-0.02 per question). The penalty is not the thing that should scare you. Time is.

What it is worth, in points

Ten questions you are unsure about

Say there are 10 questions you are not sure about. Here is what each strategy is worth, on average:

STRATEGY ON THOSE 10 QUESTIONS	EXPECTED POINTS
Leave all 10 blank	0.0
Guess blindly on all 10	-0.2
Rule out one option on each, then guess	+0.8
Rule out two options on each, then guess	+2.3
Rule out three options on each, then guess	+5.5

Five and a half points is not a rounding error. On a ranking where candidates are separated by fractions of a point, that is the difference between two universities on your preference list.

So when should you actually leave one blank?

Almost never for scoring reasons, because a blind guess only costs 0.02 points on average. Leave it blank when the honest answer is that reading it properly would cost you two minutes you need for three easier questions later in the paper. That is a time decision, not a scoring one, and it is the distinction most candidates get backwards.

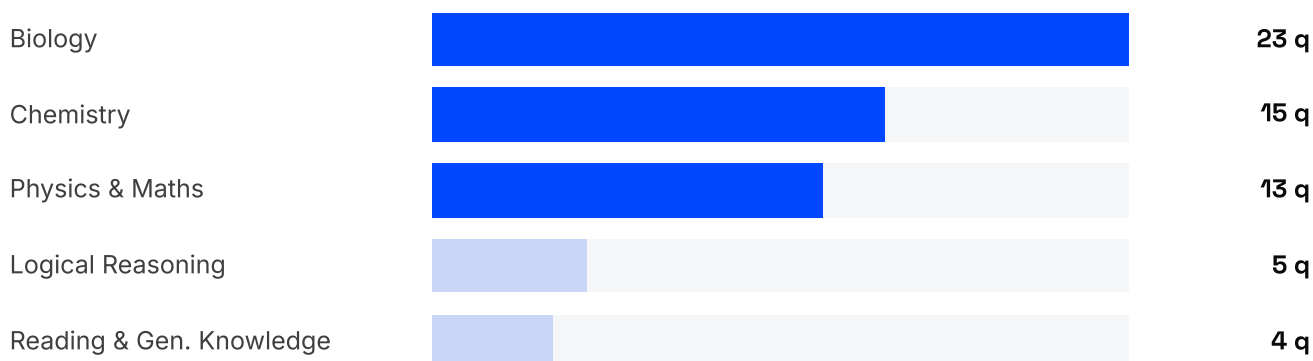
What to rehearse before exam day

Eliminating options under time pressure is a skill, not a reflex. Practise it deliberately on Day 9: for every question you cannot solve outright, force yourself to name which options are impossible before you move on. Two eliminations turn a coin flip into a genuinely positive decision.

Where your points actually are

Biology and Chemistry together are 38 of the 60 questions. That is 63% of the exam and 57 of the 90 available points, in two subjects.

Share of the exam, by section



The mismatch

Most candidates split their remaining hours roughly evenly between the subjects that intimidate them equally. The exam does not reward that. If you are giving Logical Reasoning, which is 5 questions, the same weekly hours as Biology, which is 23, you are choosing to leave points on the table.

The adjustment, not the rule

Weight is the starting point, not the whole answer. If your mock exams show you are already strong in Biology and consistently losing in Physics, shift some hours toward the weakness even though it is the smaller section. Let the weighting set your default and let your own results override it.

The exception worth knowing

Logic and Reading are only 9 questions between them, which is exactly why almost nobody trains them. That also makes them the cheapest points on the paper to improve, because you are competing against a field that has done no preparation there at all. Day 13 is built around this.

Three phases, twenty days

Each phase has one job. Doing the right thing in the wrong phase is how most final-stretch plans fall apart.

DAYS 20 TO 14 / PHASE ONE

Diagnose and repair

Find out where the points are actually leaking, then patch the biggest holes. This phase is short, targeted study driven entirely by evidence from your own mock exam, not by what feels weakest.

DAYS 13 TO 6 / PHASE TWO

Simulate and sharpen

Train under real conditions. Full timed mocks, proper reviews, timing drills, and the two neglected sections. This is where exam-day execution gets built, and it is the phase most candidates skip in favour of more reading.

DAYS 5 TO 1 / PHASE THREE

Taper and arrive

Protect what you built. Volume comes down deliberately, sleep goes up, logistics get confirmed early. You are not trying to add points in this phase. You are trying to arrive able to use the ones you already have.

If you only follow three things

1. Take a full timed mock on Day 20, cold, before revising anything.
2. Label every wrong answer by cause, not just by topic.
3. Stop studying new material on Day 5 and do not restart.

Days 20 to 14**20**

WED 9 SEP

Full timed mock, completely cold

60 questions, 100 minutes, exam conditions. No revision beforehand. Score it honestly, section by section, and write the five numbers down. This is your baseline and every decision for the next three weeks depends on it being real.

Do not: warm up with revision first. You would be measuring a version of yourself that will not exist on exam day.

19

THU 10 SEP

Review the mock properly

Go through every wrong answer and label it with one of four causes: knowledge gap, misread the question, calculation slip, or ran out of time. Count each pile. The biggest pile is your real problem, and it is often not the one you assumed.

Do not: read the correct answers, nod, and move on. That is the single most wasted hour in IMAT preparation.

18

FRI 11 SEP

Biology repair, round one

Take the three biology topics that cost you the most in the mock. Learn each properly, then immediately do 20 targeted questions on those topics only. Repair, then test the repair the same day.

Do not: start biology from the beginning of the syllabus. You have 23 questions to protect, not a textbook to finish.

17

SAT 12 SEP

Chemistry repair

Same method: your top three chemistry gaps, learned properly, then 20 targeted questions. Give periodic trends priority over memorised element facts, because trends answer more questions per minute invested.

Do not: quietly skip organic chemistry because it feels harder. Avoiding it does not make it appear less often.

16

SUN 13 SEP

Physics and Maths repair

Drill formula identification, not derivation. Give yourself scenarios and practise naming which formula applies within ten seconds. That recognition step, not the arithmetic, is where the time goes.

Do not: attempt to cover the whole physics syllabus. Kinematics, forces, and circuits recur far more than the rest.

15

MON 14 SEP

Biology repair, round two

Next three gaps, same method. Then add fifteen minutes on diagram and data-table questions specifically, because reading a graph correctly is a separate skill from knowing the biology behind it.

Do not: assume data questions will look after themselves. They are the most common blind spot in the biggest section.

14

TUE 15 SEP

Half mock, then full review

30 questions in 50 minutes, then review it the same day using the four-cause method. The point is a fast feedback loop: did the gaps you repaired this week actually close?

Do not: take a full mock today. You want the answer quickly, not another whole afternoon spent testing.

Checkpoint: what should be true by the end of Day 14

You have one full mock score broken down by section, and a second data point from the half mock. You know which of the four causes is costing you the most. You have repaired your six biggest content gaps and tested each repair the same day.

If that is not where you are, do not push on into Phase two regardless. Spend one more day finishing the diagnosis. Everything in the next eight days is built on knowing where your points are actually going, and simulating harder against an unknown problem will not tell you anything new.

Days 13 to 6

13

WED 16 SEP

The two sections nobody trains

Logic and Reading plus General Knowledge: 9 questions, 13.5 points. Work through every past-paper question you can find from both sections. There are not many, and that is exactly the point. Almost none of your competition will have done this.

Do not: dismiss them as too small to matter. 13.5 points decides places in the ranking.

12

THU 17 SEP

Full timed mock, number two

Same conditions as exam day, ideally at the same time of morning. Phone in another room. Timer visible. No pausing for any reason.

Do not: stop the clock to look something up. A mock you have quietly made easier tells you nothing useful.

11

FRI 18 SEP

Review, and compare the trend

Full four-cause review, then put mock one and mock two side by side, section by section. You are looking for direction of travel, not absolute scores.

Do not: panic over one bad section in isolation. A single dip is noise. Two in a row is a signal.

10

SAT 19 SEP

Biology and Chemistry, together

Study the genuine overlap: metabolism, enzymes, biochemistry, molecules in biological systems. Seeing the same concept from both a biological and a chemical angle builds it faster than covering it twice separately.

Do not: keep treating them as two sealed subjects. Two thirds of the exam sits across this boundary.

9

SUN 20 SEP

Timing drill and the skip decision

Two blocks of 20 questions in 33 minutes each. Practise the rule explicitly: if you have no clear path after about a minute, eliminate what you can, mark your best guess, flag it, move on. Rehearse the decision until it feels automatic.

Do not: let yourself sit on one hard question to finish it. Every extra minute there is stolen from easier questions later in the paper.

8

MON 21 SEP

Deep work on your flattest section

Whichever section has moved least across both mocks gets the entire day. Change the method, not just the hours: if reading notes has not moved it in two weeks, more reading will not move it in the third.

Do not: spend today on your strongest section because the practice feels good. It will not change your score.

7

TUE 22 SEP

Full timed mock, number three. The last one.

Full exam conditions one final time. This is your last complete simulation, and from tomorrow the work shifts entirely to consolidation.

Do not: plan any further full mocks after today. Testing yourself repeatedly in the final week costs energy and returns very little.

6

WED 23 SEP

Review, then build your one-page sheet

Final four-cause review. Then write your final sheet: the twenty facts, formulas and traps you personally keep getting wrong. One page. Handwritten if possible. This is the only thing you will revise from now on.

Do not: write ten pages of summary notes. You will not read them, and building them will eat the day.

PHASE THREE / TAPER AND ARRIVE

Days 5 to 1**5**

THU 24 SEP

Light review, and lock the logistics

Read your one-page sheet. Do 20 to 30 mixed questions, untimed, purely to stay sharp. Then confirm the practical side: exact test centre location, how long the journey takes, what documents you need, what time you must arrive.

Do not: start learning anything new. From today, new material only creates doubt about what you already know.

4

FRI 25 SEP

Half day, then stop

Your one-page sheet in the morning, then the afternoon off, properly off. Start moving your sleep schedule toward exam morning tonight so that waking early on the day is not itself a shock.

Do not: study late tonight. The sleep shift matters more than the extra hour.

3

SAT 26 SEP

Short session, strongest sections only

A short, comfortable set of questions in the areas you are best at. You are deliberately training the feeling of getting things right. Confidence on the day is not a soft factor, it changes how you handle the first hard question you meet.

Do not: take another full mock. There is nothing left it can teach you that you have time to act on.

2

SUN 27 SEP

Thirty minutes, then pack

Half an hour on your one-page sheet. Then pack everything you need: identification, documents, water, whatever your centre permits. Lay it out tonight rather than searching for it tomorrow.

Do not: cram. It will not add points and it will cost you sleep, which will.

1

MON 28 SEP

Nothing

No studying. Confirm your travel. Eat normally. Do something that is not the IMAT. Sleep early, and accept that you will probably sleep badly anyway, which is normal and does not predict how you will perform.

Do not: open forums or compare notes with other candidates. Nothing you read today can help you, and most of it will hurt.

On feeling unready

Almost every candidate we have spoken to, including the ones who scored at the very top, felt genuinely unprepared right up to test day. That feeling is close to universal. It is not evidence about your preparation, and it is not a reason to abandon the taper and cram on Day 1.

How to run a mock that actually counts

Most of what candidates call a mock exam is untimed practice done slightly faster, with a phone nearby. That is fine for content review. It is not a simulation, and it will not prepare you for the clock.

Conditions, non-negotiable

- A visible timer running the full 100 minutes, not a rough sense of elapsed time
- Phone in a different room, not face down on the desk
- A plain desk, sitting upright, only the materials permitted in the real exam
- The same time of day as your exam, wherever your schedule allows it
- No pausing, no lookups, no bathroom breaks unless genuinely necessary

The four-cause review

This is the part that produces the improvement. Every wrong answer gets exactly one label:

CAUSE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT
Knowledge gap	You did not know the content	Study that specific topic
Misread	You knew it, you answered the wrong question	Slow down on the stem, watch negations
Slip	Right method, wrong arithmetic	Check the final step before committing
Time	Rushed or never reached it	Work the skip decision, not the content

Why this matters more than it sounds

Most candidates assume every wrong answer is a knowledge gap, so they respond to every bad mock by studying more content. If half your losses are misreads and slips, more content will not move your score at all, and you will conclude you are simply not good enough. You would be wrong, and you would have diagnosed yourself with the wrong problem.

Biology

More than a third of the paper, and the section where consistent preparation pays back most reliably.

What recurs, year after year

- Cell structure, membranes and transport
- Cell division: mitosis and meiosis, and the differences that get tested
- Genetics and inheritance patterns, including simple genotype tables
- Molecular biology: DNA, RNA, transcription, translation
- Metabolism and cellular respiration
- Human physiology across the major systems

The blind spot

A meaningful share of biology questions are not pure recall. They give you a diagram, a graph, an experimental setup or a data table and ask you to interpret it. Candidates who know the biology perfectly still lose these, because reading an unfamiliar figure quickly is a separate skill that almost no study material trains directly.

One habit that fixes most of it

Before you look at the answer options, say or write in one line what the figure is actually showing. If you cannot, you are not ready to evaluate the options yet. This single step catches misreadings before they become wrong answers, and it costs about five seconds.

In the next 20 days

Do not restart biology from the beginning. Work from your mock exam: the topics that cost you points get repaired first, and everything else gets left alone. Breadth is a project for a candidate with six months, not twenty days.

Chemistry, Physics and Maths

Chemistry (15 questions)

More mechanical than its reputation suggests. Most questions are formula application and trend reasoning rather than deep theory. Four recurring ways candidates lose points here:

- **Unit conversions under time pressure.** The chemistry is right, the decimal place is not. This is a speed problem, so it has to be trained timed.
- **Memorising reactions instead of mechanisms.** Rote recall breaks the moment a question presents a slight variation of something you technically know.
- **Ignoring periodic trends.** Electronegativity, atomic radius and reactivity patterns answer more questions, faster, than isolated element facts.
- **Quietly avoiding organic chemistry.** It feels harder, so it gets deprioritised, so it stays hard. It still appears.

Physics and Mathematics (13 questions)

You are rarely asked to derive anything. You are asked to identify the right formula and apply it accurately to clean given values. That is a more approachable skill than school physics often suggests.

- **Recognition is the bottleneck.** Practise naming which formula a scenario calls for, separately from solving it.
- **The numbers are chosen to be clean.** If your answer comes out unusually messy, treat that as a signal you have made an error, not that the question is unusually hard.
- **Core areas recur.** Kinematics, forces, circuits and resistance carry a disproportionate share compared to more niche topics.

Study them together, not separately

Biochemistry, metabolism and molecular topics sit on the boundary between biology and chemistry. Scheduling those topics close together means learning the underlying concept once, thoroughly, instead of twice, partially.

The two sections your competition skipped

Logical Reasoning is 5 questions. Reading Skills and General Knowledge is 4. Nine questions, 13.5 points, and almost no candidate gives them a dedicated hour.

That is precisely why they are the cheapest improvement available to you in the final stretch. An hour spent here moves your position relative to the field far more than the same hour spent on a biology topic you have already drilled three times.

Logical Reasoning and Problems

Short, self-contained puzzles, solvable in under a minute, with deliberately clean numbers. The recurring types:

- Deductive statements: if X then Y, not Y, therefore what follows
- Spatial and seating arrangements
- Probability, percentages and discounts
- Simple combinatorics

These are not long multi-paragraph word problems. If you find yourself three minutes into one, you have almost certainly misread the setup rather than met an unusually hard question.

Reading Skills and Knowledge Acquired in Studies

A mix of short knowledge-recall items and one or two genuine passage questions drawn from journalism, literature or a product leaflet. The passage items tend to be phrased as **which CANNOT be inferred**, **which is NOT correct**, or which is the correct interpretation.

Where the points are lost

The negation. Under time pressure, candidates read "which cannot be inferred" as "which can be inferred" and confidently select a perfectly true statement. Circle or underline the negation the moment you see it, every time.

The plan for Day 13: work through every past-paper question available from both sections in one sitting. There are not many. That is the entire opportunity.

The four traps, and how to spot them

Wrong options on a well-built exam are not random. They are engineered around the specific mistakes real candidates make, which means the patterns are learnable.

1. The near-miss number

In calculation questions, one option is exactly what you get from a single plausible slip: a sign error, a decimal shift, or the wrong variant of a formula. It sits close to the correct answer specifically so that a rushed final step lands on it. This is why the last ten seconds of a calculation deserve as much care as the first minute.

2. The half-right statement

An option that is entirely true on its own but does not answer the question that was asked, or contradicts one specific detail in the passage while sounding broadly reasonable. It rewards literal reading and punishes confident skimming.

3. The scope trap

An option that takes a specific fact and overgeneralises it, or takes a general principle and narrows it too far. Both read as plausible unless you check the exact scope of the claim against the exact scope of the question.

4. The common misconception

The widely believed but incorrect version of a fact. This one tests whether you know the correct version or merely the popular one, and it is unusually common in biology.

How to train against them in three weeks

When you review a wrong answer, do not stop at the correct option. Name which of these four caught you. After two or three mock reviews you will start seeing them coming mid-question, which is the point at which this stops being knowledge and becomes instinct.

Test day

60 questions. 100 minutes. An average of 1 minute 40 seconds each, which means the paper is designed so that you cannot linger.

Run it in three passes

PASS WHAT YOU DO

First	Answer everything you can do confidently. Flag anything that does not resolve quickly and keep moving. Do not stop to admire a hard question.
Second	Return to flagged questions where you can rule options out. Remember: one elimination already makes a guess worth taking.
Third	Whatever is left. Eliminate what you can, commit, and move. A blind guess costs almost nothing. An unanswered question you could have narrowed costs real points.

Before you leave the room

Check that every answer you intended to give has actually been recorded. A question you solved correctly but left blank on the answer sheet is the most expensive mistake available on the day, and it happens more than people admit.

The first hard question

You will hit something you cannot do within the first fifteen minutes. That is designed, and it happens to everyone including the highest scorers. It is not a signal about how the rest of the paper will go. Flag it, move on, and let the plan do its job.

The practical list

- Know your exact centre, route and required arrival time by Day 5, not Day 1
- Bring the identification and documents your centre requires
- Eat something normal, not something new
- Arrive early enough that traffic cannot become a factor

What happens next

The exam is one date. The process around it runs for weeks afterwards, and understanding it in advance removes a surprising amount of anxiety.

Results timeline for this cycle

DATE	WHAT IS PUBLISHED
8 October 2026	Anonymous rankings, by candidate code rather than name
19 October 2026	Individual scores
26 October 2026	Full national ranking with names, on University

How placement actually works

Everyone is ranked nationally by score. The system then works down that ranking and, for each candidate, tries to place them at their highest-listed preference that still has a seat available. Two consequences are worth internalising now:

- **Listing your genuine first choice first does not reduce your chances elsewhere.** The system simply tries it first, then moves down your list. Ordering by what you actually want is the correct strategy.
- **The real risk is a list that is too short.** A university you would have cleared but did not list is a seat you cannot be offered. Length costs you nothing.

Later rounds exist

Placement typically runs in multiple rounds, because offered candidates decline seats and the list moves down. Missing out in the first round is genuinely not the end of the process, and every cycle people are placed later than they expected.

Dates above reflect the published schedule for the 2026 cycle at the time of writing. Always confirm current dates directly on universality.it and on your target university's own admissions page. Deadlines can shift and this guide is not a substitute for official confirmation.

If it does not go your way

Around 12,000 people sit the IMAT each year and roughly 900 enter. Most people who do not get in this cycle are not short on ability, and a rough result is information about one exam on one day, not a verdict on whether you can become a doctor.

Diagnose before you decide anything

Before choosing between a retake and another route, get honest about what actually happened. There are three very different answers, and they point in different directions:

- **The score was close.** A focused retake with a genuinely different method is often the most efficient path, and a year used deliberately is not a year wasted.
- **The preference list was too short or badly ordered.** This is the most fixable cause of all, and it has nothing to do with your preparation.
- **The gap was large.** Worth being honest about whether another full cycle fits your circumstances, or whether a different route to the same profession suits you better.

One thing we would ask of you

Do not make a year-defining decision in the first 48 hours after results. Give yourself a week, let the emotional part settle, and then look at the actual numbers. Decisions made in the immediate aftermath are almost always driven by how the result felt rather than what it showed.

And if it does go your way: the paperwork, the enrolment deadlines and the move are all their own process. Handle the exam first. The rest is admin, and admin is survivable.

We mentor a handful of candidates. Personally.

This guide is everything we could put on paper. What it cannot do is look at your specific mock results, tell you which of your four causes is actually costing you the most, and adjust next week around it.

The Lounge **Free**

Our free IMAT score predictor. Answer a few questions and see where you would realistically land right now, and which universities that score would clear. It takes a few minutes and costs nothing.

imat.club/lounge.html

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